

The Challenges of Artificial Intelligence in Schools:

"Great Potential, but First We Need to Make Students and Teachers Aware"

Interview with Guido Scorza, Member of the Data Protection Authority

(by Chiara Barison, Il Corriere della Sera-LOGIN, November 7, 2023)

Awaiting the "General States of Digital School" to be held in Bergamo on November 24 and 25, lawyer and member of the Privacy Authority Guido Scorza explains the risks of integrated digital teaching.

Among the topics that will be addressed in the eighth edition of the "General States of Digital School," the event taking place in Bergamo on November 24 and 25 ([here to register](#), [here for the complete program](#)), artificial intelligence cannot be overlooked. Proclaimed as a tool that will enable the realization of personalized teaching, tailored to the needs of each student, and thus a vehicle for equality and inclusion, it is not without risks. Especially when dealing with minors, precautions require a higher level of attention. Guido Scorza, lawyer, professor of law of new technologies and privacy, and member of the Data Protection Authority explains: "The things to keep in mind when talking about artificial intelligence in schools are transparency and the guarantee of actual self-determination for students and parents. Just because the race to digital is already underway does not mean we should accept anything without critical sense."

Digital teaching means optimizing time, but according to Scorza, the key word is "example": "If we get students used to interacting with technologies while underestimating risks and opportunities, we risk raising adults who underestimate the effects because they do not understand how what they use works." In concrete terms, it is about training both teachers and students before integrating digital tools into teaching so that students understand how the data they provide to platforms is used. "Explaining to students how algorithms work does not mean turning them into scientists," Scorza continues, "but making them aware of how their data is used as users."

Explaining is the necessary prerequisite for understanding that allows for prohibiting addiction to products created by private entities. "We need to intervene before the seductive effect of new technologies renders every effort futile. It was like this with ChatGPT," he recalls, "after many years of work in schools, I have never received as many boos as when I went to a Roman institution shortly after the blocking of OpenAI's chatbot." While it is true that we cannot passively accept that students have a generative artificial intelligence system write their essays, it is equally true that such widespread and immediate success raises some reflections. "AI should be used after rethinking learning processes: requiring students to write an essay can be overcome, so why not have them analyze a text composed by a chatbot to find errors and inaccuracies? These languages exploit our laziness as human beings; the only way to manage them is to use them actively."

From awareness comes the freedom of choice. On this point, Scorza has no doubts: "We must not transform 'digital' classes into 'digital herds,'" Scorza adds, "it is necessary to protect families who decide, for example, not to consent to the publication of photos from the school trip."